

Pre-Listing Prep & Styling Checklist — ACT

Getting your property market-ready without overspending on the wrong things.

Correct as at July 2026. General information only, not legal, financial or valuation advice.

Section 1 — Before You Spend Anything

- ☐ ☐ **Engage your conveyancer or solicitor early** to prepare your contract and disclosure documents.
- ☐ ☐ **Get a professional appraisal from 2-3 agents** before deciding your preparation budget.
- ☐ ☐ **Decide: renovate, style, or sell as-is?** Major renovations rarely return their cost dollar-for-dollar in a short pre-sale timeframe.

Section 2 — High-Return, Low-Cost Improvements

- ☐ ☐ **Declutter aggressively** — consistently the highest-return, lowest-cost step.
- ☐ ☐ **Deep clean throughout**, including often-overlooked areas.
- ☐ ☐ **Fix small, visible defects** — leaking taps, cracked tiles, chipped paint.
- ☐ ☐ **Freshen paint in neutral tones** where walls are marked or dated.
- ☐ ☐ **Service and clean heating systems before listing** — genuinely important in Canberra, where buyers inspecting through winter will notice and value functioning, efficient heating.
- ☐ ☐ **Improve street appeal.**

Section 3 — Styling Decisions

- ☐ ☐ **Consider professional staging for vacant properties.**
- ☐ ☐ **For occupied properties, focus on de-personalising** rather than full staging.
- ☐ ☐ **Get professional photography and floor plans regardless of styling budget** — not an area to cut costs on.
- ☐ ☐ **Ask your agent for their honest opinion on styling ROI** for your specific property.

Section 4 — Compliance Items to Check Before Listing

- ☐ ☐ **Check smoke alarm compliance.**
- ☐ ☐ **If your home is older, consider whether any historical asbestos assessment is relevant** — Canberra has a well-documented history with loose-fill asbestos insulation in some older homes, and buyers or their conveyancers may specifically ask about this.
- ☐ ☐ **If in a unit-titled scheme, gather your records** — recent meeting minutes, financials, and any known disputes or special levies.

Section 5 — Timing Your Campaign

- ☐ ☐ **Discuss timing with your agent relative to market conditions and Canberra's seasonal patterns**, including the significant influence of public service employment cycles on buyer activity.
- ☐ ☐ **Align your preparation timeline with your agent's proposed campaign start.**
- ☐ ☐ **Consider highlighting your property's eligibility for the new stamp duty exemption** if it's a new unit-titled property — this could be a genuine selling point given the recent reform.
- ☐ ☐ **Plan your own moving logistics in parallel** — see the separate Pre-Settlement Checklist in this series.

Quick Reference — Where to Spend, Where to Save

HIGH-RETURN, LOW-COST	OFTEN LOWER-RETURN RELATIVE TO COST
Decluttering	Full kitchen/bathroom renovations
Deep cleaning	High-end fixture upgrades
Minor repairs	Structural changes shortly before sale
Professional photography	Extensive landscaping overhauls
Heating system servicing	Full furniture replacement for occupied homes

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